

THE NPC JOB

Game Development Hackathon Proposal

Team Members

Name	Email	IndieConnect ID
Yakkala Viswanadha Kartikeya	kartikeya.yakkala@research.iiit.ac.in	stratioti
Dhiraj Chitluri	dhiraj.chitluri@students.iiit.ac.in	chitluridhiraj
Kummathi Nikhith Reddy	kummathi.reddy@research.iiit.ac.in	spectr _l
Mule Santosh Reddu	reddy.mule@students.iiit.ac.in	santhoshmstr
Krithik Kambhampati	krithik.kambhampati@students.iiit.ac.in	krithik3001

Game Overview

The NPC Job is a short 2D comedy-adventure game set in a stereotypical fantasy RPG world. However, instead of playing as the legendary hero, the player takes the role of an ordinary NPC whose job is to keep the “chosen one” alive and moving toward his quest.

The hero is extremely incompetent. He ignores instructions, attacks harmless creatures, steals objects, gets distracted by random items, and regularly creates problems that the player must solve.

The player’s primary gameplay responsibility is to manipulate the environment using **light**. Torches, lamps, mirrors, and other light sources can be activated, moved, or redirected to reveal hidden paths, objects, hazards, enemies, and mechanisms. The player therefore indirectly guides the hero rather than directly controlling him.

At first, the game appears to be a light-hearted parody of conventional RPGs. As the player progresses, small inconsistencies begin to appear. NPC reactions become increasingly unusual, and events that initially seem like jokes begin to feel strangely out of place.

The final sequence changes the player’s understanding of the entire game. Key events are rewound and shown from the perspective of the inhabitants of the world. The player discovers that the “hero” is not the true protagonist from their perspective, and that many of the actions previously presented as harmless RPG comedy had serious consequences for the world and its characters.

The goal is not simply to reveal a surprise, but to make the player reinterpret events they have already experienced.

Core Gameplay

The central gameplay loop is:

1. Observe the hero and identify what he is attempting to do.
2. Predict or react to the hero’s unpredictable behavior.
3. Manipulate the environment using light.
4. Reveal paths, objects, hazards, or mechanisms through lighting.
5. Solve environmental puzzles so the hero can continue progressing.
6. Deal with the consequences of the hero’s actions.
7. Progress to increasingly unusual areas while discovering clues about the true nature of the world.

Light is therefore a functional gameplay system rather than simply a visual effect.

Examples of interactions include:

- Lighting a hidden path so the hero can cross an area.
- Using a movable lamp or mirror to redirect light onto a mechanism.
- Revealing invisible objects or enemies.
- Creating illuminated safe zones while keeping dangerous areas in darkness.
- Manipulating shadows to alter which routes are available.

The hero’s AI provides the comedic component of the gameplay. For example, the player may illuminate an important quest item only for the hero to ignore it, break a nearby barrel instead, and accidentally trigger the correct solution.

This allows comedy to emerge from gameplay interactions rather than relying only on written dialogue.

Game Flow

Level 1 – The Village

The hero arrives and is introduced as the legendary chosen one. The player learns the basic lighting mechanics while dealing with the hero’s absurd behavior.

Level 2 – The Forest

The player uses light to reveal paths, hazards, and hidden objects. The hero's behavior creates increasingly unpredictable situations.

Level 3 – The Dungeon

Light-based puzzles become more complex. The player begins noticing inconsistencies in NPC dialogue and environmental events.

Level 4 – The Castle

The hero approaches the final objective. The world begins showing subtle indications that the player's interpretation of events may be incorrect.

Level 5 – Recontextualization

The hero apparently completes the quest. Instead of ending immediately, the game rewinds important scenes and presents them from another perspective.

Events that were previously comedic are shown again with their actual context, revealing that the inhabitants of the world experienced the hero's actions very differently.

Theme Integration

Theme	Implementation
Comic	The game parodies RPG conventions through an incompetent and unpredictable hero. Humor comes from NPC interactions, exaggerated animations, absurd quests, and gameplay situations caused by the hero's behavior.
Light	Light is the central gameplay mechanic. The player controls torches, lamps, mirrors, and illuminated areas to reveal hidden paths and objects, activate mechanisms, expose hazards, and guide the hero through the environment.
Twist	The game initially presents the player as an NPC assisting a heroic protagonist. The final section rewinds major events and shows them from the perspective of the world, revealing that the player's interpretation of the hero and his actions was fundamentally incomplete. Previous comedic moments are given a different meaning.

Judging Criteria Alignment

Theme Interpretation – 20%

All three themes are integrated directly into the gameplay and narrative. Comedy comes from the hero's behavior, Light is the primary environmental mechanic, and the Twist changes the interpretation of the player's previous actions.

Gameplay and Mechanics – 30%

The game focuses on a clear and repeatable gameplay loop built around observation, environmental manipulation, and light-based puzzle solving. The hero's autonomous behavior creates dynamic situations instead of making the game a purely linear narrative experience.

Technical Stability – 20%

The project will be intentionally scoped as a short 2D game with a small number of reusable environments and mechanics. The game will be tested continuously and exported as a browser-playable Godot build for deployment on itch.io.

Audio-Visual Cohesion – 20%

The initial game will use a colorful, exaggerated fantasy-RPG visual style with expressive animations and comedic sound effects. During the final recontextualization, the same environments, sounds, and events will be presented with altered audio-visual treatment to reinforce the change in perspective.

Hour 12 Plan Compliance – 10%

By Hour 12, the team will target a complete playable vertical slice containing:

- Basic player movement.
- Basic hero AI and autonomous movement.
- One working light-based interaction.
- One complete environmental puzzle.
- One comedic hero interaction.
- A functional level-completion flow.

- Temporary art and audio sufficient for testing.

The remaining development time will focus on additional levels, expanded lighting mechanics, art, audio, narrative clues, the final recontextualization sequence, browser testing, and polish.

Technical Scope

The game will be developed using **Godot** as a 2D browser-playable project. The implementation will prioritize reusable systems for character movement, simple hero AI, light sources, environmental interactions, dialogue, and level transitions.

The project will target a compact experience of approximately **15–30 minutes**, allowing the team to prioritize polish, reliability, and the quality of the final twist over excessive content.

Expected Player Experience

The intended progression is:

**“This is a funny RPG parody.” → “This hero is an idiot.” → “Something feels wrong.” → “Wait...”
→ “I completely misunderstood what I was seeing.”**

The core design principle is that the twist should not merely provide new information. It should **change the meaning of information the player has already experienced**. This allows the Comic, Twist, and Light themes to work together as part of one coherent gameplay experience.